02 The s-Block Elements

s-Block:

The s-block elements of the Periodic Table are those in which the last electron enters the outermost s-orbital. As the s-orbital can accommodate only two electrons, two groups (1 & 2) belong to the s-block of the Periodic Table. Group 1 of the Periodic Table consists of the elements: lithium, sodium, potassium, rubidium, caesium and francium. They are collectively known as the alkali metals. These are so called because they form hydroxides on reaction with water which are strongly alkaline in nature. The elements of Group 2 include beryllium, magnesium, calcium, strontium, barium and radium. These elements with the exception of beryllium are commonly known as the alkaline earth metals. These are so called because their oxides and hydroxides are alkaline in nature and these metal oxides are found in the earth's crust*.

Among the alkali metals sodium and potassium are abundant and lithium, rubidium and caesium have much lower abundances. Francium is highly radioactive; its longest-lived isotope $_{223}Fr$ has a half-life of only 21 minutes. Of the alkaline earth metals calcium and magnesium rank fifth and sixth in abundance respectively in the earth's crust. Strontium and barium have much lower abundances. Beryllium is rare and radium is the rarest of all comprising only 10^{-10} per cent of igneous rocks.

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The general electronic configuration of s-block elements is [noble gas] ns^1 for alkali metals and [noble gas] ns^2 for alkaline earth metals.

Lithium and beryllium, the first elements of Group 1 and Group 2 respectively exhibit some properties which are different from those of the other members of the respective group. In these anomalous properties they resemble the second element of the following group. Thus, lithium shows similarities to magnesium and beryllium to aluminium in many of their properties. This type of diagonal similarity is commonly referred to as diagonal relationship in the periodic table. The diagonal relationship is due to the similarity in ionic sizes and /or charge/radius ratio of the elements. Monovalent sodium and potassium ions and divalent magnesium and calcium ions are found in large proportions in biological fluids. These ions perform important biological functions such as maintenance of ion balance and nerve impulse conduction.

Group 1 Elements : Alkali Metals:

The alkali metals show regular trends in their physical and chemical properties with the increasing atomic number. The atomic, physical and chemical properties of alkali metals are discussed below.

Electronic Configuration

All the alkali metals have one valence electron, ns^1 outside the noble gas core. The loosely held s-electron in the outermost valence shell of these elements makes them the most electropositive metals. They readily lose electron to give monovalent $M^{\oplus}$ ions. Hence, they are never found in free state in nature.

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Element	Symbol	Electronic configuration
Lithium	Li	$1s^2 2s^1$
Sodium	Na	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^1$
Potassium	K	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 4s^1$
Rubidium	Rb	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 3d^{10} 4s^2 4p^6 5s^1$
Caesium	Cs	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 3d^{10} 4s^2 4p^6 4d^{10} 5s^2 5p^6 6s^1$ or [Xe] $6s^1$
Francium	Fr	[Rn] $7s^1$

Atomic and Ionic Radii

Li < Na < K < Rb < Cs

Increase down the group, because value of n (principal quantum number) increases.

Ionization Enthalpy

Li > Na > K > Rb > Cs.

This is because the effect of increasing size outweighs the increasing nuclear charge, and the outermost electron is very well screened from the nuclear charge.

Hydration Enthalpy

The hydration enthalpies of alkali metal ions decrease with increase in ionic sizes.

$Li^{\oplus} > Na^{\oplus} > K^{\oplus} > Rb^{\oplus} > Cs^{\oplus}$

$Li^{\oplus}$ has maximum degree of hydration and for this reason lithium salts are mostly hydrated,

e.g., $LiCl \cdot 2H_2O$

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Physical Properties

(i) All the alkali metals are silvery white, soft and light metals.

(ii) Because of the large size, these elements have low density which increases down the group from Li to Cs. However, potassium is lighter than sodium.
Li < K < Na < Rb < Cs.

(iii) The melting and boiling points of the alkali metals are low indicating weak metallic bonding due to the presence of only a single valence electron in them.

(iv) The alkali metals and their salts impart characteristic colour to an oxidizing flame. This is because the heat from the flame excites the outermost orbital electron to a higher energy level. When the excited electron comes back to the ground state, there is emission of radiation in the visible region as given below :

Metal	Li	Na	K	Rb	Cs
Colour	Crimson red	Yellow	Violet	Red violet	Blue
λ(nm)	670.8	589.2	766.5	780.0	455.5

(v) Alkali metals can therefore, be detected by the respective flame tests and can be determined by flame photometry or atomic absorption spectroscopy.

(vi) These elements when irradiated with light, the light energy absorbed may be sufficient to make an atom lose electron.
This property makes potassium, Rubidium and caesium as electrodes in photoelectric cells.
But mainly caesium is used in devising photoelectric cells.

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Table : Atomic and Physical Properties of the Alkali Metals

Property	Lithium Li	Sodium Na	Potassium K	Rubidium Rb	Caesium Cs	Francium Fr
Atomic number	3	11	19	37	55	87
Atomic mass (g mol^{-1})	6.94	22.99	39.10	85.47	132.91	(223)
Electronic configuration	$[He]2s^1$	$[Ne]3s^1$	$[Ar]4s^1$	$[Kr]5s^1$	$[Xe]6s^1$	$[Rn]7s$
Ionization enthalpy/kJ mol^{-1}	520	496	419	403	376	~375
Hydration enthalpy/kJ mol^{-1}	–506	–406	–330	–310	–276	-
Metallic radius/pm	152	186	227	248	265	-
Ionic radius $M^{\oplus}$/pm	76	102	137	152	167	(180)
m.p./K	454	371	336	312	302	-
b.p/K	1615	1156	1032	961	944	-
Density / gcm^{-3}	0.53	0.97	0.86	1.53	1.90	-
Standard Potentials E^{-} /V for (M^{σ}/M)	–3.04	–2.714	–2.925	–2.930	–2.927	-
Occurrence in lithosphere	18*	2.27*	1.87**	78-12*	2-6*	$\sim 10^{-18}$*

*ppm (part per million), ** percentage by weight; † Lithosphere: The Earth's outer layer: its crust and part of the upper mantle.

Chemical Properties:

The alkali metals are highly reactive due to their large size and low ionization enthalpy. The reactivity of these metals increases down the group.

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(i) Reactivity towards air : The alkali metals tarnish in dry air due to the formation of their oxides which in turn react with moisture to form hydroxides. They burn vigorously in oxygen forming oxides. Lithium forms monoxide, sodium forms peroxide, the other metals form superoxide's. The superoxide O_2^- ion is stable only in the presence of large cations such as K, Rb, Cs.

$4Li + O_2 \rightarrow 2Li_2O$ (oxide)

$2Na + O_2 \rightarrow Na_2O_2$ (peroxide)

$M + O_2 \rightarrow MO_2$ (superoxide)

(M = K, Rb, Cs)

In all these oxides the oxidation state of the alkali metal is +1. Lithium shows exceptional behaviour in reacting directly with nitrogen of air to form the nitride, Li_3N as well. Because of their high reactivity towards air and water, **alkali metals are normally kept in kerosene oil.**

(but Li is kept in paraffin wax cotted wraps under kerosene)

(ii) Reactivity towards water : The alkali metals react with water to form hydroxide and dihydrogen.

$2M + 2H_2O \rightarrow 2MOH + H_2$

(M = an alkali metal)

It may be noted that although lithium has most negative $E^{\ominus}$ value, its reaction with water is less vigorous than that of sodium which has the least negative $E^{\ominus}$ value among the alkali metals. This behaviour of lithium is attributed to its small size and very high hydration energy. Other metals of the group react explosively with water.

They also react with proton donors such as alcohol, gaseous ammonia and alkynes.

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(iii) **Reactivity towards dihydrogen:** The alkali metals react with dihydrogen at about 673K (lithium at 1073K) to form hydrides. All the alkali metal hydrides are ionic solids with high melting points.

$2M + H_2 \rightarrow 2M^{\oplus}H^{\ominus}$

(iv) **Reactivity towards halogens:** The alkali metals readily react vigorously with halogens to form ionic halides, $M^{\oplus}X^{\ominus}$. However, lithium halides are somewhat covalent. It is because of the high polarisation capability of lithium ion (The distortion of electron cloud of the anion by the cation is called polarisation). The $Li^{\oplus}$ ion is very small in size and has high tendency to distort electron cloud around the negative halide ion. Since anion with large size can be easily distorted, among halides, lithium iodide is the most covalent in nature.

(v) **Reducing nature :** The alkali metals are strong reducing agents, lithium being the most and sodium the least powerful. The standard electrode potential ($E^{\ominus}$) which measures the reducing power represents the overall change :

$M(s) \rightarrow M(g)$	sublimation enthalpy
$M(g) \rightarrow M^{\oplus}(g) + e^{\ominus}$	ionization enthalpy
$M^{\oplus}(g) + H_2O \rightarrow M^{\oplus}(aq)$	hydration enthalpy

With the small size of its ion, lithium has the highest hydration enthalpy which accounts for its high negative $E^{\ominus}$ value and its high reducing power.

(vi) **Solutions in liquid ammonia :** The alkali metals dissolve in liquid ammonia giving deep blue solutions which are conducting in nature.

$M+(x + y)NH_3(\ell) \rightarrow [M(NH_3)_x]^{\oplus} + [e(NH_3)y]^{\ominus}$

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The blue colour of the solution is due to the ammoniated electron which absorbs energy in the visible region of light and thus imparts blue colour to the solution. The solutions are paramagnetic and on standing slowly liberate hydrogen resulting in the formation of amide.

$M^{\oplus}_{(am)} + e^{\ominus} + NH_3(\ell) \rightarrow MNH_{2(am)} + \frac{1}{2}H_2(g)$ (where 'am' denotes solution in ammonia.)

In concentrated solution, (excess NH_3) the blue colour changes to bronze colour and becomes diamagnetic.

(vii) **Reaction with N_2**

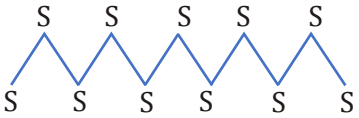
Only Lithium reacts with N_2 to form ionic lithium nitride Li_3N.

$3Li + \frac{1}{2}N_2 \rightarrow Li_3N$

Other member of group do not form nitride by reaction with N_2

(viii) **Sulphides**

All metals react with S forming sulphides such as Na_2S and polysulphides Na_2S_n (n = 2, 3, 4, 5 or 6). The polysulphide ions are made from zig-zag chains of sulphur atoms.



Na_2S is used to make organic sulphur dye stuffs and in the leather industry to rename hair from hides.

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Uses :

1. Lithium metal is used to make useful alloys, for example with lead to make 'white metal' bearings for motor engines, with aluminium to make aircraft parts, and with magnesium to make armour plates.
2. It is used in thermonuclear reactions.
3. Lithium is also used to make electrochemical cells. Sodium is used to make a Na/Pb alloy needed to make $PbEt_4$ and $PbMe_4$. These organ lead compounds were earlier used as anti-knock additives to petrol, but nowadays vehicles use lead-free petrol.
4. Liquid sodium metal is used as a coolant in fast breeder nuclear reactors.
5. Potassium has a vital role in biological systems. Potassium chloride is used as a fertilizer. Potassium hydroxide is used in the manufacture of soft soap. It is also used as an excellent absorbent of carbon dioxide.
6. Caesium is used in devising photoelectric cells.

General Characteristics of The Compounds of The Alkali Metals:

All the common compounds of the alkali metals are generally ionic in nature. General characteristics of some of their compounds are discussed here.

Oxides and Hydroxides

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On combustion in excess of air, lithium forms mainly the oxide, Li_2O (plus some peroxide Li_2O_2), sodium forms the peroxide, Na_2O_2 (and some superoxide NaO_2) whilst potassium, rubidium and caesium form the superoxide's, MO_2. Under appropriate conditions pure compounds M_2O, M_2O_2 and MO_2 may be prepared. The increasing stability of the peroxide or superoxide, as the size of the metal ion increases, is due to the stabilisation of large anions by larger cations through lattice energy effects. These oxides are easily hydrolysed by water to form the hydroxides according to the following reactions :

$$M_2O + H_2O \rightarrow 2M^{\oplus} + 2OH^{\ominus}$$

$$M_2O_2 + 2H_2O \rightarrow 2M^{\oplus} + 2OH^{\ominus} + H_2O_2$$

$$2MO_2 + 2H_2O \rightarrow 2M^{\oplus} + 2OH^{\ominus} + H_2O_2 + O_2$$

The oxides and the peroxides are colourless when pure, but the superoxides are yellow or orange in colour. The superoxides are also paramagnetic. Sodium peroxide is widely used as an oxidising agent in inorganic chemistry.

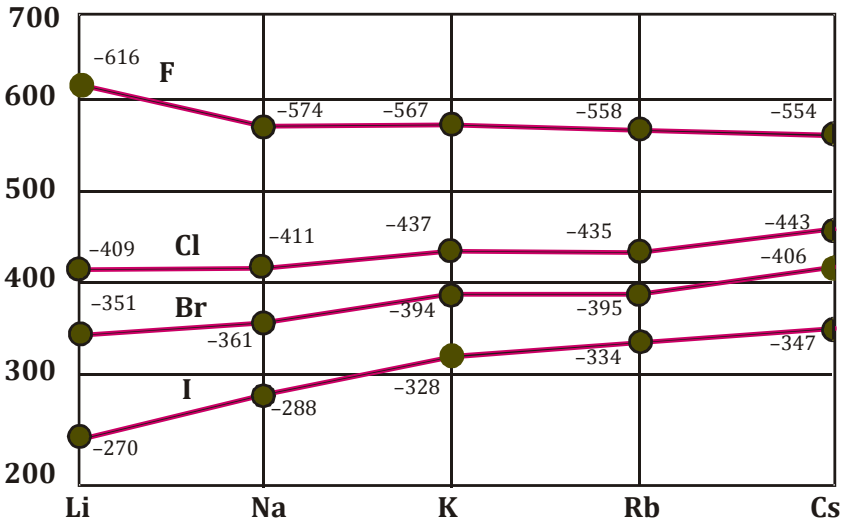
The hydroxides which are obtained by the reaction of the oxides with water are all white crystalline solids. The alkali metal hydroxides are the strongest of all bases and dissolve freely in water with evolution of much heat on account of intense hydration.

The basis nature (or strength) of the hydroxide increases regularly down the group.

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Halides

The alkali metal halides, MX, (X=F,Cl,Br,I) are all high melting, colourless crystalline solids. They can be prepared by the reaction of the appropriate oxide, hydroxide or carbonate with aqueous hydrohalic acid (HX). All of these halides have high negative enthalpies of formation; the $\Delta_f H^{\ominus}$ values for fluorides become less negative as we go down the group, whilst the reverse is true for $\Delta_f H^{\ominus}$ for chlorides, bromides and iodides. For a given metal $\Delta_f H^{\ominus}$ always becomes less negative from fluoride to iodide.



The standard enthalpies of formation of the halides of Group 1 elements at 298 K

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Salts of Oxo-Acids:

Oxo-acids are those in which the acidic proton is on a hydroxyl group with an oxo group attached to the same atom e.g., carbonic acid, H_2CO_3 ($OC(OH)_2$; sulphuric acid, H_2SO_4 ($O_2S(OH)_2$). The alkali metals form salts with all the oxo-acids. They are generally soluble in water and thermally stable.

Their carbonates (M_2CO_3) and in most cases the hydrogencarbonates ($MHCO_3$) also are highly stable to heat. As the electropositive character increases down the group, the stability of the carbonates and hydorgencarbonates increases. Lithium carbonate is not so stable to heat; lithium being very small in size polarises a large $CO_3^{2\ominus}$ ion leading to the formation of more stable Li_2O and CO_2. Its hydrogencarbonate does not exist as a solid.

Anomalous Properties of Lithium:

The anomalous behaviour of lithium is due to the : (i) exceptionally small size of its atom and ion, and (ii) high polarising power (i.e., charge/ radius ratio). (iii) absence of d-orbitals in the valance shell. As a result, there is increased covalent character of lithium compounds which is responsible for their solubility in organic solvents. Further, lithium shows diagonal relationship to magnesium which has been discussed subsequently.

Points of Difference between Lithium and other Alkali Metals:

(i) Lithium is much harder. Its m.p. and b.p. are higher than the other alkali metals.

(ii) Lithium is least reactive but the strongest reducing agent among all the alkali metals. On combustion in air it forms mainly monoxide, Li_2O and the nitride, Li_3N unlike other alkali metals.

(iii) LiCl is deliquescent and crystallises as a hydrate, $LiCl.2H_2O$ whereas other alkali metal chlorides do not form hydrates. As they are not deliquescent and forms anhydrous salts when crystallised.

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(iv) Lithium hydrogencarbonate (bicarbonate) is not obtained in the solid form but it is known in solution while all other elements form solid hydrogencarbonates.

(v) Lithium unlike other alkali metals forms no ethynide on reaction with ethyne.

(vi) Lithium nitrate when heated gives lithium oxide, Li_2O, whereas other alkali metal nitrates decompose to give the corresponding nitrite.

$$4LiNO_3 \rightarrow 2Li_2O + 4NO_2 + O_2$$

$$2NaNO_3 \rightarrow 2NaNO_2 + O_2$$

(vii) LiF and Li_2O are comparatively much less soluble in water than the corresponding compounds of other alkali metals.

Points of Similarities between Lithium and Magnesium:

The similarity between lithium and magnesium is particularly striking and arises because of their similar sizes : atomic radii, Li = 152 pm, Mg = 160 pm; ionic radii : $Li^{\oplus}$ = 76 pm, $Mg^{2\oplus}$= 72 pm. The main points of similarity are :

(i) Both lithium and magnesium are harder and lighter than other elements in the respective groups.

(ii) Lithium and magnesium react slowly with water. Their oxides and hydroxides are much less soluble and their hydroxides decompose on heating. Both form a nitride, Li_3N and Mg_3N_2, by direct combination with nitrogen.

(iii) The oxides, Li_2O and MgO do not combine with excess oxygen to give any superoxide.

(iv) The carbonates of lithium and magnesium decompose easily on heating to form the oxides and CO_2. Solid hydrogen carbonates are not formed by lithium and magnesium.

(v) Both LiCl and $MgCl_2$ are soluble in ethanol.

(vi) Both LiCl and $MgCl_2$ are deliquescent and crystallise from aqueous solution as hydrates, $LiCl\cdot 2H_2O$ and $MgCl_2\cdot 8H_2O$.

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Some Important Compounds of Sodium:

Industrially important compounds of sodium include sodium carbonate, sodium hydroxide, sodium chloride and sodium bicarbonate. The large scale production of these compounds and their uses are described below :

Sodium Oxide (Na_2O):

Preparation:

(i) It is obtained by burning sodium at 180°C in a limited supply of air or oxygen and distilling off the excess of sodium in vacuum. (But it may contain little peroxide also)

$$2Na + \frac{1}{2}O_2 \xrightarrow{180^\circ} Na_2O$$

(ii) Pure Na_2O can be prepared By heating sodium peroxide, nitrate or nitrite with sodium.

$$Na_2O_2 + 2Na \xrightarrow{\Delta} 2Na_2O$$

$$2NaNO_3 + 10Na \xrightarrow{\Delta} 6Na_2O + N_2$$

$$2NaNO_2 + 6Na \xrightarrow{\Delta} 4Na_2O + N_2$$

Properties :

(i) It is white amorphous mass.

(ii) It decomposes at 400°C into sodium peroxide and sodium

$$2Na_2O \xrightarrow{400^\circ C} Na_2O_2 + 2Na$$

(iii) It dissolves violently in water, yielding caustic soda.

$$Na_2O + H_2O \longrightarrow 2NaOH + \text{large heat}$$

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Sodium Peroxides (Na_2O_2) :

Preparation: It is formed by heating the metal in excess of air or oxygen at 300°, which is free from moisture and CO_2.

$$2Na + \underset{\text{(excess)}}{O_2} \xrightarrow{\Delta} Na_2O_2$$

Properties :

(i) It is a pale yellow solid, (powder) becoming white in (moistured)air from the formation of a film of NaOH and Na_2CO_3.

(ii) In cold water (~0°C) produces H_2O_2 but at room temperature produces O_2. In ice-cold mineral acids also produces H_2O_2.

$$Na_2O_2 + 2H_2O \xrightarrow{\sim 0^\circ C} 2NaOH + H_2O_2$$
$$2Na_2O_2 + 2H_2O \xrightarrow{25^\circ C} 4NaOH + O_2$$
$$Na_2O_2 + H_2SO_4 \xrightarrow{\sim 0^\circ C} Na_2SO_4 + H_2O_2$$

(iii) It reacts with CO and CO_2, giving sodium carbonate and oxygen and hence it is used for purifying air in a confined space e.g. submarine, ill-ventilated room,

$$2Na_2O_2 + 2CO_2 \longrightarrow 2Na_2CO_3 + O_2$$
$$Na_2O_2 + CO \longrightarrow Na_2CO_3$$

(iv) It is an oxidising agent and oxidises charcoal, CO, NH_3, SO_2.

$$3Na_2O_2 + 2C \longrightarrow 2Na_2CO_3 + 2Na \text{ [deposition of metallic Na]}$$
$$CO + Na_2O_2 \longrightarrow Na_2CO_3$$
$$SO_2 + Na_2O_2 \longrightarrow Na_2SO_4$$
$$2NH_3 + 3Na_2O_2 \longrightarrow 6NaOH + N_2$$

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(v) It contains peroxide ion $[-O-O-]^{2\ominus}$

Uses:

(i) For preparing H_2O_2, O_2

(ii) Oxygenating the air in submarines (reaction with CO_2)

(iii) Oxidising agent in the laboratory.

Sodium Carbonate (Washing Soda), $Na_2CO_3 \cdot 10H_2O$:

Sodium carbonate is generally prepared by **Solvay Process**. In this process, advantage is taken of the low solubility of sodium hydrogencarbonate whereby it gets precipitated in the reaction of sodium chloride with ammonium hydrogencarbonate. The latter is prepared by passing CO_2 to a concentrated solution of sodium chloride saturated with ammonia, where ammonium carbonate followed by ammonium hydrogencarbonate are formed.

The equations for the complete process may be written as:

$$2NH_3 + H_2O + CO_2 \rightarrow (NH_4)_2\,CO_3$$
$$(NH_4)_2CO_3 + H_2O + CO_2 \rightarrow 2NH_4HCO_3$$
$$NH_4HCO_3 + NaCl \rightarrow NH_4Cl + NaHCO_3$$

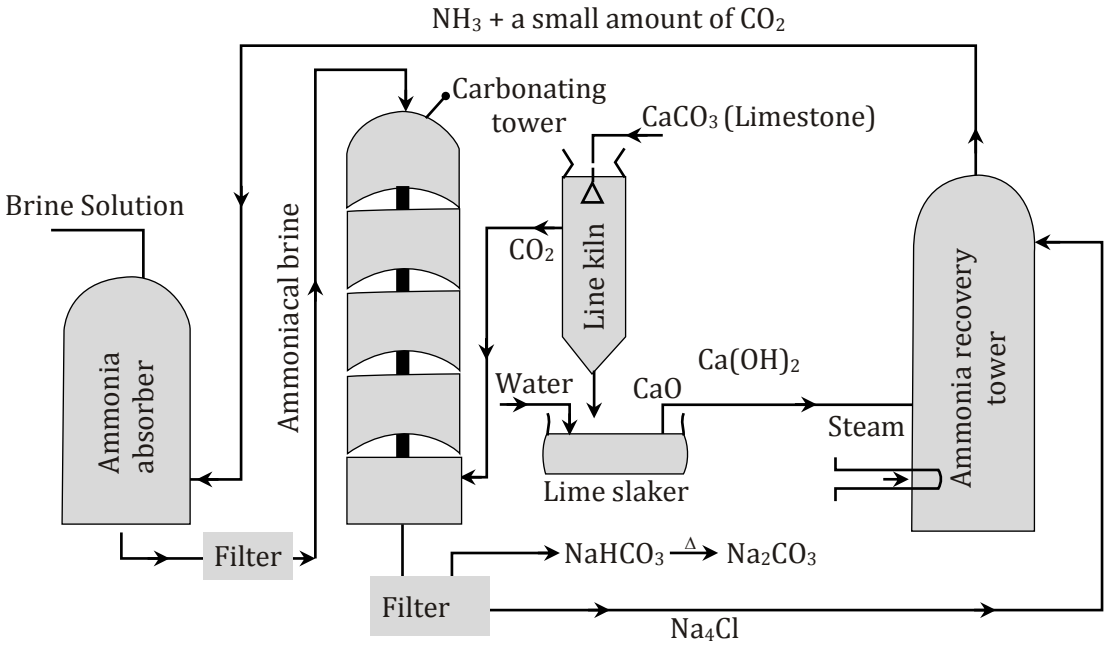
Sodium hydrogencarbonate crystal separates. These are heated to give sodium carbonate.

$$2NaHCO_3 \rightarrow Na_2CO_3 + CO_2 + H_2O$$

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In this process NH_3 is recovered when the solution containing NH_4Cl is treated with $Ca(OH)_2$. Calcium chloride is obtained as a by-product.

$$2NH_4Cl + Ca(OH)_2 \rightarrow 2NH_3 + CaCl_2 + H_2O$$



Note: It may be mentioned here that Solvay process cannot be extended to the manufacture of potassium carbonate because potassium hydrogencarbonate is too soluble to be precipitated by the addition of ammonium hydrogencarbonate to a saturated solution of potassium chloride.

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Properties : Sodium carbonate is a white crystalline solid which exists as a decahydrate, $Na_2CO_3 \cdot 10H_2O$. This is also called washing soda. It is readily soluble in water and these crystals are efflorescence on exposure to dry air giving the monohydrate $Na_2CO_3.H_2O$ On heating, the decahydrate loses its water of crystallisation to form monohydrate. Above 373K, the monohydrate becomes completely anhydrous and changes to a white powder called soda ash.

$$Na_2CO_3.10H_2O \xrightarrow{373\,K} Na_2CO_3.H_2O + 9H_2O$$

$$Na_2CO_3.H_2O \xrightarrow{>373\,K} Na_2CO_3 + H_2O$$

Carbonate part of sodium carbonate gets hydrolysed by water to form an alkaline solution.

$$CO_3^{2\ominus} + H_2O \longrightarrow HCO_3^{\ominus} + OH^{\ominus}$$

Uses:

(i) It is used in water softening, laundering and cleaning.

(ii) It is used in the manufacture of glass, soap, borax and caustic soda.

(iii) It is used in paper paints petroleum and textile industries.

(iv) It is an important laboratory reagent both in qualitative and quantitative analysis.

Note: K_2CO_3 cannot be prepared by **Solvay process** because $KHCO_3$ is soluble in water and cannot be separated from NH_4Cl.

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Sodium Chloride, NaCl:

The most abundant source of sodium chloride is sea water which contains 2.7 to 2.9% by mass of the salt. In tropical countries like India, common salt is generally obtained by evaporation of sea water. Approximately 50 lakh tons of salt are produced annually in India by solar evaporation. Crude sodium chloride, generally obtained by crystallisation of brine solution, contains sodium sulphate, calcium sulphate, calcium chloride and magnesium chloride as impurities. Calcium chloride, $CaCl_2$, and magnesium chloride, $MgCl_2$ are impurities because they are deliquescent (absorb moisture easily from the atmosphere).

To obtain pure sodium chloride, the crude salt is dissolved in minimum amount of water and filtered to remove insoluble impurities. The solution is then saturated with hydrogen chloride gas. Crystals of pure sodium chloride separate out. Calcium and magnesium chloride, being more soluble than sodium chloride, remain in solution.

Sodium chloride melts at 1081K. It has a solubility of 36.0 g in 100 g of water at 273 K. The solubility does not increase appreciably with increase in temperature.

Uses :

(i) It is used as a common salt or table salt for domestic purpose.

(ii) It is used for the preparation of Na_2O_2, NaOH and Na_2CO_3.

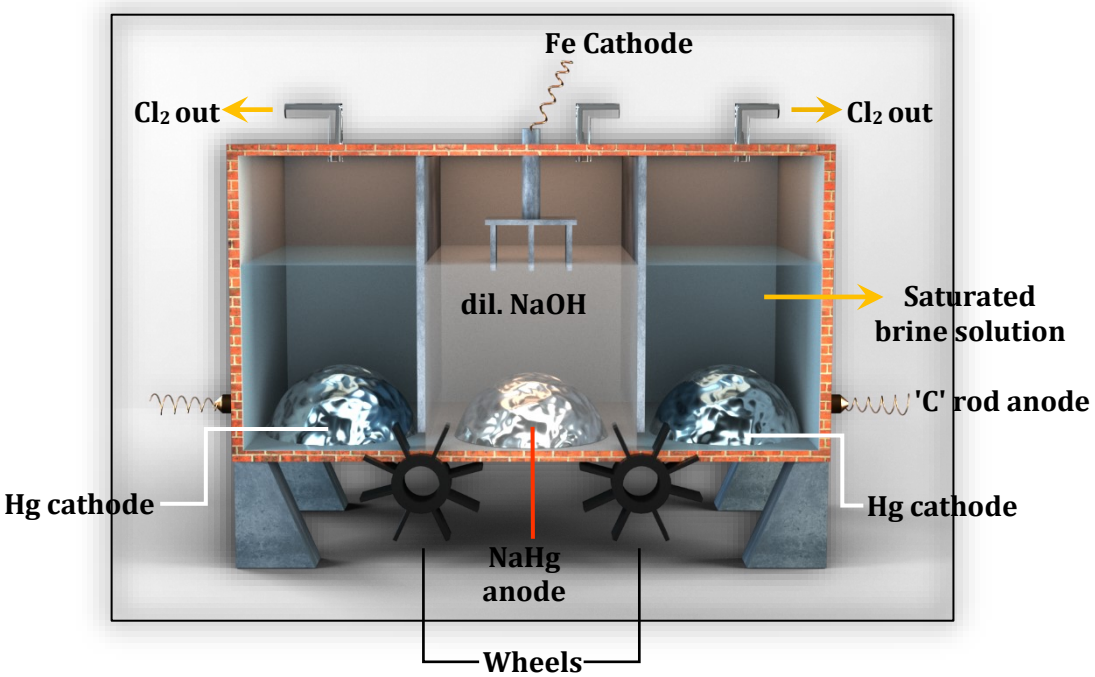
(iii) It is used to prepare freezing mixture in laboratory [Ice-common salt mixture is called freezing mixture and temperature goes down to –23°C.]

(iv) In impure form it is used for melting ice and snow on road.

(v) It is used as a preservative of food like fish, meat etc.

Sodium Hydroxide (Caustic Soda), NaOH:

Sodium hydroxide is generally prepared commercially by the electrolysis of sodium chloride in Castner-Kellner cell. A brine solution is electrolysed using a mercury cathode and a carbon anode. Sodium metal discharged at the cathode combines with mercury to form sodium amalgam. Chlorine gas is evolved at the anode. (The anodes are now made of steel coated with titanium. Titanium is very resistance to corrosion)



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Cathode : $Na^{\oplus} + e^{\ominus} \xrightarrow{Hg}$ Sodium amalgam

Anode : $Cl^{\ominus} \rightarrow \frac{1}{2} Cl_2 + e^{\ominus}$

The amalgam is treated with water to give sodium hydroxide and hydrogen gas.

$$2Na\text{-amalgam} + 2H_2O \rightarrow 2NaOH + 2Hg + H_2$$

Properties →

Sodium hydroxide is a white, translucent solid and is soapy to touch. It melts at 591 K. It is readily soluble in water to give a strong alkaline solution. Crystals of sodium hydroxide are deliquescent. The sodium hydroxide solution at the surface reacts with the CO_2 in the atmosphere to form Na_2CO_3.

The solution of NaOH has a corrosive action on the skin as it attacks the proteins of the skin therefore called caustic soda.

Uses : It is used in

(i) The manufacture of soap, paper, artificial silk and a number of chemicals,

(ii) In petroleum refining,

(iii) In the purification of bauxite,

(iv) In the textile industries for mercerising cotton fabrics,

(v) for the preparation of pure fats and oils

(vi) As a laboratory reagent.

(vii) In the preparation of Alumina, silicate glass etc.

Sodium Hydrogencarbonate (Baking Soda), $NaHCO_3$

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Sodium hydrogencarbonate is known as baking soda because it decomposes on heating to generate bubbles of carbon dioxide (leaving holes in cakes or pastries and making them light and fluffy).

Sodium hydrogencarbonate is made by passing CO_2 gas in a solution of sodium carbonate. The white crystalline powder of sodium hydrogencarbonate, being less soluble, gets separated out.

$$Na_2CO_3 + H_2O + CO_2 \rightarrow 2NaHCO_3$$

Uses : hydrogencarbonate is a mild antiseptic for skin infections and as an antacid in medicines. **It is used in dry fire extinguishers.**

Potassium carbonate, K_2CO_3

It is also called potash or pearl ash. It cannot be made by the use of Solvay process as potassium bicarbonate is more soluble than sodium bicarbonate. However, it can be prepared by **Le-Blanc process**. KCl is first converted into K_2SO_4. Potassium sulphate (K_2SO_4) is then heated with $CaCO_3$ and carbon.

$$KCl + H_2SO_4 \longrightarrow KHSO_4 + HCl$$

$$KHSO_4 + KCl \longrightarrow K_2SO_4 + HCl$$

$$K_2SO_4 + CaCO_3 + 2C \longrightarrow K_2CO_3 + CaS + 2CO_2$$

It is a white powder, deliquescent in nature. It is highly soluble in water. Its M.P. is 1173 K.

Uses : It is used in the manufacture of hard glass. The mixture of K_2CO_3 and Na_2CO_3 is used a **fusion mixture** in laboratory. It is used as drying agent in laboratory die to its hygroscopic nature.

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Biological Importance of Sodium and Potassium:

A typical 70 kg man contains about 90 g of Na and 170 g of K compared with only 5 g of iron and 0.06 g of copper. Sodium ions are found primarily on the outside of cells, being located in blood plasma and in the interstitial fluid which surrounds the cells. These ions participate in the transmission of nerve signals, in regulating the flow of water across cell membranes and in the transport of sugars and amino acids into cells. Sodium and potassium, although so similar chemically, differ quantitatively in their ability to penetrate cell membranes, in their transport mechanisms and in their efficiency to activate enzymes.

Thus, potassium ions are the most abundant cations within cell fluids, where they activate many enzymes, participate in the oxidation of glucose to produce ATP and, with sodium, are responsible for the transmission of nerve signals.

There is a very considerable variation in the concentration of sodium and potassium ions found on the opposite sides of cell membranes. As a typical example, in blood plasma, sodium is present to the extent of 143 $mmolL^{-1}$, whereas the potassium level is only 5 $mmolL^{-1}$ within the red blood cells. These concentrations change to 10 $mmolL^{-1}$ ($Na^{\oplus}$) and 105 $mmolL^{-1}$ ($K^{\oplus}$). These ionic gradients demonstrate that a discriminatory mechanism, called the sodium-potassium pump, operates across the cell membranes which consumes more than one-third of the ATP used by a resting animal and about 15 kg per 24 h in a resting human.

Group 2 Elements : Alkaline Earth Metals:

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The group 2 elements comprise beryllium, magnesium, calcium, strontium, barium and radium. They follow alkali metals in the periodic table. These (except beryllium) are known as alkaline earth metals. The first element beryllium differs from the rest of the members and shows diagonal relationship to aluminium. The atomic and physical properties of the alkaline earth metals are shown in Table.

Electronic Configuration:

These elements have two electrons in the s -orbital of the valence shell. Their general electronic configuration may be represented as [noble gas] ns^2. Like alkali metals, the compounds of these elements are also predominantly ionic.

Element	Symbol	Electronic configuration
Beryllium	Be	$1s^2 2s^2$
Magnesium	Mg	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2$
Calcium	Ca	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 4s^2$
Strontium	Sr	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 3d^{10} 4s^2 4p^6 5s^2$
Barium	Ba	$1s^2 2s^2 2p^6 3s^2 3p^6 3d^{10} 4s^2 4p^6 4d^{10} 5s^2 5p^6 6s^2$ or $[Xe]6s^2$
Radium	Ra	$[Rn]7s^2$

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Table : Atomic and Physical Properties of the Alkaline Earth Metals

Property	Beryllium Be	Magnesium Mg	Calcium Ca	Strontium Sr	Barium Ba	Radium Ra
Atomic number	4	12	20	38	56	88
Atomic mass (g mol^{-1})	9.01	24.31	40.08	87.62	137.33	226.03
Electronic configuration	[He]2s	[Ne]$3s^2$	[Ar]$4s^2$	[Kr]$5s^2$	[Xe]$6s^2$	[Rn]$7s^2$
Ionization enthalpy (I)/kJ mol^{-1}	889	737	590	549	503	509
Ionization enthalpy (II)/kJ mol^{-1}	1757	1450	1145	1064	965	979
Hydration enthalpy/kJ mol^{-1}	–2494	–1921	–1577	–1443	–1305	-
Metallic radius/pm	111	160	197	215	222	-
Ionic radius $M^{\oplus}$/pm	31	72	100	118	135	148
m.p./K	1560	924	1124	1062	1002	973
b.p/K	2745	1363	1767	1655	2078	(1973)
Density / gcm^{-3}	1.84	1.74	1.55	2.63	3.59	(5.5)
Standard Potentials E^- /V for ($M^{\oplus}/M$)	–1.97	–2.36	–2.84	–2.89	–2.92	–2.92
Occurrence in lithosphere	2*	2.76**	4.6**	384*	390*	10^{-6}*

* ppm (part per million), ** percentage by weight

Atomic and Ionic Radii:

The atomic and ionic radii of the alkaline earth metals are smaller than those of the :
Corresponding alkali metals in the same periods. This is due to the increased nuclear charge in these elements. Within the group, the atomic and ionic radii increase with increase in atomic number.

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Ionization Enthalpies:

Be > Mg > Ca > Sr > Ba

Down the group IE decreases due to increase in size

IE_1 of AM < IE_1 of AEM

IE_2 of AM > IE_2 of AEM

[where AM = Alkali metal, AEM = Alkaline earth metal]

Reason : IE_1 of AEM is large due to increased nuclear charge in AEM as compared to AM but IE_2 of AM is large because second electron in AM is to be removed from cation which has already acquired noble gas configuration.

Hydration Enthalpies:

Like alkali metal ions, the hydration enthalpies of alkaline earth metal ions decrease with increase in ionic size down the group.

$Be^{2\oplus} > Mg^{2\oplus} > Ca^{2\oplus} > Sr^{2\oplus} > Ba^{2\oplus}$

The hydration enthalpies of alkaline earth metal ions are larger than those of alkali metal ions. Thus, compounds of alkaline earth metals are more extensively hydrated than those of alkali metals, e.g., $MgCl_2$ and $CaCl_2$ exist as $MgCl_2.8H_2O$, $SrCl_2 \cdot 6H_2O$, and $BaCl_2 \cdot 2H_2O$ while NaCl and KCl do not form such hydrates. Tendency to form hydrated salts diereses down the group.

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Physical Properties:

(i) The alkaline earth metals, in general, are silvery white, lustrous but tarnish rapidly when exposed to air and relatively soft but harder than the alkali metals. Beryllium and magnesium appear to be somewhat greyish.

(ii) The melting and boiling points of these metals are higher than the corresponding alkali metals due to smaller sizes. The trend is, however, not systematic.

(iii) Because of the low ionisation enthalpies, they are strongly electropositive in nature. The electropositive character increases down the group from Be to Ba.

(iv) Calcium, strontium and barium impart characteristic brick red, crimson and apple green colours respectively to the flame. In flame the electrons are excited to higher energy levels and when they drop back to the ground state, energy is emitted in the form of visible light. The electrons in beryllium and magnesium are too strongly bound to get excited by flame. Hence, these elements do not impart any colour to the flame. The flame test for Ca, Sr and Ba is helpful in their detection in qualitative analysis and estimation by flame photometry.

(v) The alkaline earth metals like those of alkali metals have high electrical and thermal conductivities which are typical characteristics of metals.

Chemical Properties:

The alkaline earth metals are less reactive than the alkali metals. The reactivity of these elements increases on going down the group.

(i) Reactivity towards air : Beryllium and magnesium are kinetically inert to oxygen and water because of the formation of an oxide film on their surface. However, powdered beryllium burns brilliantly on ignition in air to give BeO and Be_3N_2. Magnesium is more electropositive and burns with dazzling brilliance in air to give MgO and Mg_3N_2. Calcium, strontium and barium are readily attacked by air to form the oxide and nitride.

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$$2Be + O_2 \xrightarrow{heat} 2BeO$$

$$3Be + N_2 \xrightarrow{\Delta} Be_3N_2$$

Further the tendency of the metals to form higher oxides such as peroxide increases on moving down the group.

(ii) Reactivity towards water.

Reaction with H_2O: AEM have lesser tendency to react with water as compared to AM. They form hydroxides and liberate H_2 on reaction with H_2O

$$M + 2H_2O \xrightarrow{\Delta} M(OH)_2 + H_2$$

* Be is inert towards water even with steam at higher temperature
* Magnesium react with boiling water as

$$Mg + 2H_2O \rightarrow Mg(OH)_2 + H_2$$

or $Mg + H_2O \rightarrow MgO + H_2O$

MgO forms protective layer, that is why it does not react readily unless layer is removed amalgamating with Hg. Other metals react quite readily (Ca, Sr, Ba) as reactivity increases on moving down the group.

Note:

$Be(OH)_2$ is amphoteric but other hydroxides are basic in nature.

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(iii) Reactivity towards the halogens : All the alkaline earth metals combine with halogen at elevated temperatures forming their halides.

$M + X_2 \rightarrow MX_2$ (X = F, Cl, Br, I)

Thermal decomposition of $(NH_4)_2BeF_4$ is the best route for the preparation of BeF_2, and $BeCl_2$ is conveniently made from the oxide.

$BeO + C + Cl_2 \underset{}{\overset{600-800K}{\rightleftharpoons}} BeCl_2 + CO$

(iv) Reactivity towards hydrogen : All the elements except beryllium combine with hydrogen upon heating to form their hydrides.

MH_2, BeH_2, however, can be prepared by the reaction of $BeCl_2$ with $LiAlH_4$.

$2BeCl_2 + LiAlH_4 \rightarrow 2BeH_2 + LiCl + AlCl_3$

(v) Reactivity towards acids : (AEM) Alkaline earth metals react with acids & liberate H_2

$Mg + 2HCl \rightarrow MgCl_2 + H_2$

Be is amphoteric as it also react with NaOH, other metals do not react as they are purely basic.

$Be + 2NaOH \rightarrow Be(OH)_2 \xrightarrow{\text{excess NaOH}} [Be(OH)_4]^{2\ominus}$

Be does not react with conc. Nitric acid due to formation of very thin protective oxide film on the surface.

(vi) Reducing nature : Like alkali metals, the alkaline earth metals are strong reducing agents. This is indicated by large negative values of their reduction potentials. However, their reducing power is less than those of their corresponding alkali metals. Beryllium has less negative value compared to other alkaline earth metals. However, its reducing nature is due to large hydration energy associated with the small size of $Be^{2\oplus}$ ion and relatively large value of the atomization enthalpy (same as ΔH_{sub} for $M_{(s)}$) of the metal.

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(vii) Solutions in liquid ammonia: Like alkali metals, the alkaline earth metals (mainly Ca, Sr, Ba) dissolve in liquid ammonia to give deep blue black solutions forming ammoniated ions.

$M + (x + y)\ NH_3 \rightarrow [M(NH_3)_x]^{2\oplus} + 2[e(NH_3)_y]^{\ominus}$

From these solutions, the ammoniates, $[M(NH_3)_6]^{2\oplus}$ can be recovered.

These solutions decompose very slowly forming amides and evolving hydrogen gas. Concentrated solutions of the metal in ammonia are bronze colored, due to formation of clusters.

Uses :

Be : Beryllium is used in the manufacture of alloys. Copper-beryllium alloys are used in the preparation of high strength springs. Metallic beryllium is used for making windows of X-ray tubes.

Mg : Magnesium forms alloys with aluminium, zinc, manganese and tin. Magnesium-aluminium alloys being light in mass are used in air-craft construction. Magnesium (powder and ribbon) is used in flash powders and bulbs, incendiary bombs (targeted fire bomb) and signals. A suspension of magnesium hydroxide in water (called milk of magnesia) is used as antacid in medicine. Magnesium carbonate is an ingredient of toothpaste.

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Ca : Calcium is used in the extraction of metals from oxides which are difficult to reduce with carbon. Calcium and barium metals, owing to their reactivity with oxygen and nitrogen at elevated temperatures, have often been used to remove air from vacuum tubes.

Ra : Radium salts are used in radiotherapy, for example, in the treatment of cancer.

General Characteristics of Compounds of The Alkaline Earth Metals:

The dipositive oxidation state ($M^{2\oplus}$) is the predominant valence of Group 2 elements. The alkaline earth metals form compounds which are predominantly ionic but less ionic than the corresponding compounds of alkali metals. This is due to increased nuclear charge and smaller size. The oxides and other compounds of beryllium and magnesium are more covalent than those formed by the heavier and large sized members (Ca, Sr, Ba). The general characteristics of some of the compounds of alkali earth metals are described below.

(i) Oxides and Hydroxides :

The alkaline earth metals burn in oxygen to form the monoxide, MO which, except for BeO, have rock-salt structure. The BeO is essentially covalent in nature. The enthalpies of formation of these oxides are quite high and consequently they are very stable to heat. BeO is amphoteric while oxides of other elements are ionic in nature. All these oxides except BeO are basic in nature and react with water to form sparingly soluble hydroxides.

$$MO + H_2O \rightarrow M(OH)_2$$

The solubility, thermal stability and the basic character of these hydroxides increase with increasing atomic number from $Mg(OH)_2$ to $Ba(OH)_2$. The alkaline earth metal hydroxides are, however, less basic and less stable than alkali metal hydroxides. Beryllium hydroxide is amphoteric in nature as it reacts with acid and alkali both.

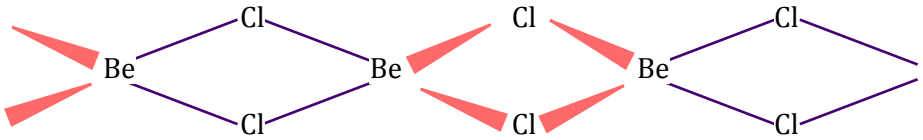
$$Be(OH)_2 + 2OH^{\ominus} \rightarrow [Be(OH)_4]^{2\ominus}$$

Beryllate ion

$$Be(OH)_2 + 2HCl \rightarrow 2H_2O + BeCl_2$$

(ii) Halides :

Except for beryllium halides, all other halides of alkaline earth metals are ionic in nature. Beryllium halides are essentially covalent and soluble in organic solvents. Beryllium chloride has a chain structure in the solid state as shown below:



In the vapour phase $BeCl_2$ tends to form a chloro-bridged dimer which dissociates into the linear monomer at high temperatures of the order of 1200 K. The tendency to form halide hydrates gradually decreases (for example, $MgCl_2 \cdot 8H_2O$, $CaCl_2 \cdot 6H_2O$, $SrCl_2 \cdot 6H_2O$ and $BaCl_2 \cdot 2H_2O$) down the group. The dehydration of hydrated chlorides, bromides and iodides of Ca, Sr and Ba can be achieved on heating; however, the corresponding hydrated halides of Be and Mg on heating suffer hydrolysis. The fluorides are relatively less soluble than the chlorides owing to their high lattice energies.

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(iii) Salts of Oxoacids : The alkaline earth metals also form salts of oxoacids. Some of these are :

Carbonates : Carbonates of alkaline earth metals are insoluble in water and can be precipitated by addition of a sodium or ammonium carbonate solution to a solution of a soluble salt of these metals.

Ex. $(NH_4)_2CO_3 + CaCl_2 \rightarrow CaCO_3\downarrow + NH_4Cl$

The solubility of carbonates in water decreases as the atomic number of the metal ion increases. All the carbonates decompose on heating to give carbon dioxide and the oxide.

Ex. $MCO_3 \rightarrow MO + CO_2$ (M = Be, Mg, Ca, Sr, Ba)

Beryllium carbonate is unstable and can be kept only in the atmosphere of CO_2.

Ex. $BeCO_3 \rightarrow BeO + CO_2$

The thermal stability increases with increasing cationic size.

Sulphates : The sulphates of the alkaline earth metals are all white solids and stable to heat. $BeSO_4$, and $MgSO_4$ are readily soluble in water; the solubility decreases from $CaSO_4$ to $BaSO_4$. The greater hydration enthalpies of $Be^{2\oplus}$ and $Mg^{2\oplus}$ ions overcome the lattice enthalpy factor and therefore their sulphates are soluble in water. Due to presence of soluble $MgSO_4$ & $CaSO_4$ water becomes hard water.

Nitrates : The nitrates are made by dissolution of the carbonates in dilute nitric acid. Magnesium nitrate crystallises with six molecules of water ($Mg(NO_3)2 \cdot 6H_2O$), whereas barium nitrate crystallises as the anhydrous salt ($Ba(NO_3)_2$) This again shows a decreasing tendency to form hydrates with increasing size and decreasing hydration enthalpy. All of them decompose on heating to give the oxide like lithium nitrate.

$2M(NO_3)_2 \rightarrow 2MO + 4NO_2 + O_2$

(M = Be, Mg, Ca, Sr, Ba)

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Note:

The solubility of alkaline earth metal hydroxides in water increase down the group?

Reason :

Among alkaline earth metal hydroxides, the anion being common the cationic radius will influence the lattice enthalpy. Since lattice enthalpy decreases much more than the hydration enthalpy with increasing ionic size, the solubility increases as we go down the group.

Note:

The solubility of alkaline earth metal carbonates and sulphates in water decrease down the group?

Reason :

The size of anions being much larger compared to cations, the lattice enthalpy will remain almost constant within a particular group. Since the hydration enthalpies decrease down the group, solubility will decrease as found for alkaline earth metal carbonates and sulphates.

Anomalous Behaviour of Beryllium:

Beryllium, the first member of the Group 2 metals, shows anomalous behaviour as compared to magnesium and rest of the members. Further, it shows diagonal relationship to aluminium which is discussed subsequently.

(i) Beryllium has exceptionally small atomic and ionic sizes and thus does not compare well with other members of the group. Because of high ionisation enthalpy and small size it forms compounds which are largely covalent and get easily hydrolysed.

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(ii) Beryllium does not exhibit coordination number more than four as in its valence shell there are only four orbitals. The remaining members of the group can have a coordination number of six by making use of d-orbitals.

(iii) The oxide and hydroxide of beryllium, unlike the hydroxides of other elements in the group, are amphoteric in nature.

Diagonal Relationship between Beryllium and Aluminium

The ionic radius of $Be^{2\oplus}$ is estimated to be 31 pm; the charge/radius ratio is nearly the same as that of the $Al^{3\oplus}$ ion. Hence beryllium resembles aluminium in some ways. Some of the similarities are:

(i) Like aluminium, beryllium is not readily attacked by acids because of the presence of an oxide film on the surface of the metal.

(ii) Beryllium hydroxide dissolves in excess of alkali to give a beryllate ion, $[Be(OH)_4]^{2\ominus}$ just as aluminium hydroxide gives aluminate ion, $[Al(OH)_4]^{\ominus}$.

(iii) The chlorides of both beryllium and aluminium have $Cl^{\ominus}$ bridged chloride structure in vapour phase. Both the chlorides are soluble in organic solvents and are strong Lewis acids. They are used as Friedel Craft catalysts.

(iv) Beryllium and aluminium ions have strong tendency to form complexes, $BeF_4^{2\ominus}$, $AlF_6^{3\ominus}$

Some Important Compounds of Calcium:

Important compounds of calcium are calcium oxide, calcium hydroxide, calcium sulphate, calcium carbonate and cement. These are industrially important compounds. The large scale preparation of these compounds and their uses are described below.

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Calcium Oxide or Quick Lime, CaO:

It is prepared on a commercial scale by heating limestone ($CaCO_3$) in a rotary kiln at 1070-1270 K.

$$CaCO_3 \underset{}{\overset{\text{heat}}{\rightleftharpoons}} CaO + CO_2$$

The carbon dioxide is removed as soon as it is produced to enable the reaction to proceed to completion. Calcium oxide is a white amorphous solid. It has a melting point of 2870 K. On exposure to atmosphere, it absorbs moisture and carbon dioxide.

$$CaO + H_2O \rightarrow Ca(OH)_2$$

$$CaO + CO_2 \rightarrow CaCO_3$$

The addition of limited amount of water breaks the lump of lime. This process is called slaking of lime. Quick lime slaked with soda gives solid sodalime. Being a basic oxide, it combines with acidic oxides at high temperature.

$$CaO + SiO_2 \rightarrow CaSiO_3$$

$$6CaO + P_4O_{10} \rightarrow 2Ca_3(PO_4)_2$$

Uses :

(i) It is an important primary material for manufacturing cement and is the cheapest form of alkali.

(ii) It is used in the manufacture of sodium carbonate from caustic soda.

(iii) It is employed in the purification of sugar and in the manufacture of dye stuffs.

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Calcium Hydroxide (Slaked lime), $Ca(OH)_2$

Calcium hydroxide is prepared by adding water to quick lime, CaO.

It is a white amorphous powder. It is sparingly soluble in water. The aqueous solution is known as lime water and a suspension of slaked lime in water is known as milk of lime.

When carbon dioxide is passed through lime water (milk of lime) it turns milky due to the formation of calcium carbonate.

$$Ca(OH)_2 + CO_2 \rightarrow CaCO_3 + H_2O$$

On passing excess of carbon dioxide, the precipitate dissolves to form calcium hydrogen carbonate and milkyness disappears.

$$CaCO_3 + CO_2 + H_2O \rightarrow Ca(HCO_3)_2$$

Milk of lime reacts with chlorine to form hypochlorite, a constituent of bleaching powder.

$$2Ca(OH)_2 + 2Cl_2 \rightarrow CaCl_2 + Ca(OCl)_2 + 2H_2O$$

Uses:

(i) It is used in the preparation of mortar, a building material.

(ii) It is used in whitewash due to its disinfectant nature.

(iii) It is used in glass making, in tanning industry, for the preparation of bleaching powder and for purification of sugar.

Calcium Carbonate, $CaCO_3$

Calcium carbonate occurs in nature in several forms like limestone, chalk, marble etc. It can be prepared by passing carbon dioxide through slaked lime or by the addition of sodium carbonate to calcium chloride.

$$Ca(OH)_2 + CO_2 \rightarrow CaCO_3 + H_2O$$

$$CaCl_2 + Na_2CO_3 \rightarrow CaCO_3 + 2NaCl$$

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Excess of carbon dioxide should be avoided since this leads to the formation of water soluble calcium hydrogencarbonate.

Calcium carbonate is a white fluffy powder. It is almost insoluble in water. When heated to 1200 K, it decomposes to evolve carbon dioxide.

$$CaCO_3 \xrightarrow{1200K} CaO + CO_2$$

It reacts with dilute acid to liberate carbon dioxide.

$$CaCO_3 + 2HCl \rightarrow CaCl_2 + H_2O + CO_2$$

$$CaCO_3 + H_2SO_4 \rightarrow CaSO_4 + H_2O + CO_2$$

Uses:

It is used as a building material in the form of marble and in the manufacture of quick lime. Calcium carbonate along with magnesium carbonate is used as a flux in the extraction of metals such as iron. Specially precipitated $CaCO_3$ is extensively used in the manufacture of high-quality paper. It is also used as an antacid, mild abrasive in toothpaste, a constituent of chewing gum, and a filler in cosmetics.

Calcium Sulphate (Plaster of Paris), $CaSO_4 \cdot \frac{1}{2} H_2O$

It is a hemihydrate of calcium sulphate. It is obtained when gypsum, $CaSO_4 \cdot 2H_2O$, is heated to 393 K.

$$2(CaSO_4.2H_2O) \rightarrow 2(CaSO_4).H_2O + 3H_2O$$

Above 393 K, no water of crystallisation is left and anhydrous calcium sulphate, $CaSO_4$ is formed. This is known as 'dead burnt plaster'.

It has a remarkable property of setting with water. On mixing with an adequate quantity of water it forms a plastic mass that gets into a hard solid in 5 to 15 minutes.

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Uses:
The largest use of Plaster of Paris is in the building industry as well as wall plasters and to make fireproof walls. It is used for immobilising the affected part of organ where there is a bone fracture or sprain. It is also employed in dentistry, in ornamental work and for making casts of statues and busts.

Cement: Cement is an important building material. It was first introduced in England in 1824 by Joseph Aspdin. It is also called **'Portland cement'** because it resembles with the natural limestone quarried in the Isle of Portland, England.

Cement is a product obtained by combining a material rich in lime, CaO with other material such as clay which contains silica, SiO_2 along with the oxides of aluminium, iron and magnesium. The average composition of Portland cement is:

CaO, 50-60%; SiO_2, 20-25%; Al_2O_3, 5-10%; MgO, 2-3%; Fe_2O_3, 1-2% and SO_3, 1-2%. For a good quality cement, the ratio of silica (SiO_2) to alumina (Al_2O_3) should be between 2.5 and 4 and the ratio of lime (CaO) to the total of the oxides of silicon (SiO_2) aluminium (Al_2O_3) and iron (Fe_2O_3) should be as close as possible to 2.

The raw materials for the manufacture of cement are limestone and clay. When clay and lime are strongly heated together they fuse and react to form 'cement clinker'. This clinker is mixed with 2-3% by weight of gypsum ($CaSO_4 \cdot 2H_2O$) to form cement. Thus important ingredients present in Portland cement are dicalcium silicate (Ca_2SiO_4) 26%, tricalcium silicate (Ca_3SiO_5) 51% and tricalcium aluminate ($Ca_3Al_2O_6$) 11%.

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Setting of Cement : When mixed with water, the setting of cement takes place to give a hard mass. This is due to the hydration of the molecules of the constituents and their rearrangement. The purpose of adding gypsum is only to slow down the process of setting of the cement so that it gets sufficiently hardened.

Uses:
Cement has become a commodity of national necessity for any country next to iron and steel. It is used in concrete and reinforced concrete, in plastering and in the construction of bridges, dams and buildings.

Biological Importance of Magnesium and Calcium:

An adult body contains about 25 g of Mg and 1200 g of Ca compared with only 5 g of iron and 0.06 g of copper. The daily requirement in the human body has been estimated to be 200–300 mg. All enzymes that utilise ATP in phosphate transfer require magnesium as the cofactor. The main pigment for the absorption of light in plants is chlorophyll which contains magnesium. About 99 % of body calcium is present in bones and teeth. It also plays important roles in neuromuscular function, interneuronal transmission, cell membrane integrity and blood coagulation. The calcium concentration in plasma is regulated at about 100 mgL^{-1}. It is maintained by two hormones: calcitonin and parathyroid hormone. Do you know that bone is not an inert and unchanging substance but is continuously being solubilised and redeposited to the extent of 400 mg per day in man? All this calcium passes through the plasma.

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